Building a Podcast Website That Actually Competes

Market research, content architecture, and feature advisory

Prepared by Juergen Berkessel, Polymash · April 2026

AGENDA

What We'll Cover

01

Market reality — who's out there, what they charge, and where they fall short

02

The content problem — why every current builder gets podcast content wrong

03

SEO & AI search — what actually drives podcast discoverability on the web

04

The feature set — what a competitive podcast website builder needs

MARKET SCALE

The Podcast Market in 2026

$40B	584M	603K	175M
Global podcast market	Global listeners	Active podcasts	U.S. monthly listeners

4.58M podcasts registered, but only 603,000 actively publishing (episode in last 90 days). That active base is the addressable market for a website builder.

WHAT PODCASTERS STRUGGLE WITH

Pain Points (558-Creator Survey)

WHAT PODCASTERS SPEND

The $100/Month Inflection Point

The spending threshold

Podcasters spending $100+/month get 44% more downloads per episode than those spending $0.

The website builder market sits in the $15-40/month zone — accessible to both groups.

The $19-29/month range is the sweet spot. Podpage anchors at $19. Beating their feature set at $29 is the play.

COMPETITIVE LANDSCAPE

Dedicated Podcast Website Builders

Platform	Price	What It Does	What It Lacks
Podpage	$12-39/mo	RSS sync, episode pages, AI show notes (Elite only)	Design flexibility, AI gated at $39, no social
Beamly	~$12/mo	RSS sync, multi-show, memberships	Small, less proven
OnPodium	$7/mo	Episode pages, basic SEO	Budget, limited features
ZipiStream	$7.44/mo	Sponsor-focused	Niche

Podpage is essentially alone. The others are marginal. AI features locked behind $39/mo Elite tier. Clear opening at $15-30.

HOSTING PLATFORMS

Built-In Websites: "Good Enough" Isn't

Transistor
$19-199/mo
Best aesthetics of the hosting platforms. Dynamic show notes on Pro+.

Captivate
$19-99/mo
Good templates, strong monetization tools. No content enrichment.

Buzzsprout
$0-79/mo
Largest community. Functional but basic website. Cohost AI as add-on.

Podbean
$0-99/mo
Best built-in marketplace. Dated design.

Libsyn / Castos
$12-150/mo
Legacy players. Website is an afterthought.

They all do the same thing: pull the RSS description onto a template page and call it a website. None differentiate between app micro-copy and what a website should actually contain.

THE CORE PROBLEM

The RSS Description Is Not Show Notes

RSS Feed (Micro-Copy)

- 200-400 character teaser
- 2-4 essential links max
- MM:SS timestamps for in-app nav
- Guest name + one-line title
- No transcript (4,000 char limit)
- No SEO markup (RSS not indexed)
- No calls to action

Website (Full Show Notes)

- 500-2,000+ word article
- Full categorized resource library
- Clickable timestamps → player
- Full guest bio, social links, related episodes
- Full searchable transcript
- JSON-LD structured data, FAQ schema
- Newsletter signup, lead magnets, affiliate links

Every current builder puts the RSS micro-copy on a template page and calls it "show notes." This is like using a movie trailer as the movie.

WHO GETS IT RIGHT

How Top Podcasts Handle Their Websites

Tim Ferriss	Show notes function as standalone essays — extensive resource lists, timestamps, guest quotes, written analysis beyond the audio
Lex Fridman	Searchable transcripts with clickable timestamps that control the player — click a line, audio jumps to that moment
Huberman Lab	Transcripts are premium content — paid Supercast subscribers only. Monetizing what others give away
99% Invisible	Free transcript pages, fully indexed by Google, creating organic search discovery pathways
Stuff You Should Know	Consistent notes across 2,700+ episodes — long-term SEO compounding at scale

These are content platforms, not episode listings. That is the structural insight a builder should encode.

SEO OPPORTUNITY

Google Ranks Web Pages, Not Podcasts

A podcast distributed only through RSS is invisible to Google. The audio lives behind a play button in Apple Podcasts or Spotify — Google cannot index it.

Evidence

This American Life — 6.68% increase in organic search traffic after adding transcripts

80% of listeners visit a website in response to podcast mentions

59% of top 100 business podcasts post transcripts on their websites

What works for podcast SEO

- Full transcripts (largest single multiplier)
- PodcastEpisode JSON-LD on every page
- FAQ schema (captures featured snippets)
- XML sitemap with episode-level entries
- Pillar-and-cluster internal linking
- YouTube publishing (most cited in AI Overviews)

AI SEARCH

The New Discovery Frontier

AI-powered search engines — ChatGPT, Perplexity, Google AI Overviews — are rapidly becoming how people discover information. These systems prioritize different signals than traditional search.

What AI search engines consume

- Structured data they can parse and cite
- Content that directly answers questions (FAQ format)
- Multi-format presence (website + YouTube + social)
- Brand mentions across authoritative sources

A podcast website builder that generates AI-readable structured data by default — not as a premium feature — would be positioned for where search is going, not where it has been. JSON-LD, FAQ schema, and semantic HTML should be baked into the architecture, not upsold.

EPISODE PAGE ARCHITECTURE

What an Episode Page Should Contain

01 Episode header (title, number, date, duration, guest)

02 Embedded player with chapters & deep-linking

03 Table of contents with clickable timestamps

04 Key takeaways (3-7 bullet points)

05 Full show notes (500-2,000 words)

06 Guest bio with social links

07 Categorized resources & links

08 Full transcript (searchable, with speakers)

09 FAQ section with JSON-LD schema

10 Newsletter / email signup CTA

11 Related episodes (internal linking)

The structural play: Even without AI-generated content, simply providing the right sections and containers gives podcasters a framework that no current builder offers. Whether content is manually entered, pasted from tools like CastMagic, or AI-generated natively is a product decision. The page architecture is the differentiator.

STRUCTURED DATA

JSON-LD That Should Be Automatic

PodcastEpisode

`title, datePublished, duration, audioUrl, episodeNumber, partOfSeries reference`

Every episode page

PodcastSeries

`name, description, webFeed (RSS URL), image, author, sameAs (platform links)`

Main podcast page

FAQPage

`3–5 questions per episode, visible on page (Google req), captures featured snippets, cited by AI Overviews`

Any episode with FAQ content

Plus auto-generated XML sitemap with episode-level entries, BreadcrumbList for navigation, and Person schema for host/guest. All of this should be generated from the page structure — zero manual effort.

PLAYER WIDGET

The Player Gap Nobody Talks About

What top podcasts have (custom-built)

- Synchronized transcript display
- Timestamp deep-linking (?t=120)
- Chapter navigation with titles
- Clip sharing for visitors
- Speed controls, skip silence, boost voice

What off-the-shelf players offer

- No synced transcript (any player)
- No clip sharing (any player)
- Timestamp: only Beamly + Transistor
- Chapters: fragmented, inconsistent
- Styling: basic color/size options

A builder with a player that has synced transcripts and timestamp deep-linking would immediately stand out. This is universally custom-built today — only the top-tier shows have it.

SOCIAL MEDIA

The Missing Promotional Workflow

A single episode should produce 15-25 content assets. Most creators produce 1-3 because the workflow is fragmented.

Episode Publishes → **Website Auto-Generates** → **Social Content Generated** → **Traffic → Website**

The critical decision: social posts should drive traffic to the website, not to Apple Podcasts or Spotify. The website is owned territory. Podcast apps are rented land. Every listener on the website can be captured via newsletter, presented with more content, and monetized.

WHAT CONVERTS

Features Podcasters Will Actually Pay For

High Willingness

1. Time savings on content creation
2. SEO & discoverability tools
3. Monetization infrastructure
4. Custom domain

Moderate Willingness

5. Analytics & retention data
6. Email / newsletter integration
7. Transcript publication

Low / Don't Gate

8. Design templates
9. Community / comments
10. Niche integrations

Pricing signal: Freemium conversion in podcast tools is 2-8%. The $19-29/month range is the sweet spot. Custom domain is the #1 free-to-paid conversion driver. Annual billing discount of 30-35% is expected.

MUST-HAVE PAGES

Essential Podcast Website Structure

Home

Show description, latest episode player, host intro, subscribe buttons across platforms

Episodes

Searchable archive, filters by topic/guest, individual episode pages with full structure

About

Host bio, show mission, media kit, schema-optimized for AI search engines

Blog

Articles derived from episodes, high SEO value, pillar content for topic clusters

Contact / Guest

Guest applications, media inquiries, sponsorship info, booking form

Subscribe

Newsletter signup, platform links, RSS feed link, email capture with value prop

CONTENT TOOLS LANDSCAPE

AI Content Tools Exist — But Have No Website

Tool	Price	What It Generates
CastMagic	$19-179/mo	Transcripts, show notes, blog posts, social, newsletters
Capsho	~$99/mo	20+ marketing assets, graphics, clips, brand voice learning
Deciphr AI	$5-169/mo	Transcripts, SEO articles, white papers, FAQs, newsletters
Swell AI	$8.99/60min	Transcripts, show notes, blog posts, social media
Podium	$12-14/mo	Transcripts, show notes, chapters, social posts

These tools produce great content. But podcasters copy-paste it into Podpage or WordPress. A website builder that integrates with — or replaces — these tools closes the loop.

SOCIAL PROMOTION TOOLS

The Fragmented Social Toolkit

Opus Clip
$15-29/mo
AI viral clip extraction from video podcasts. "Virality score" per clip.

Headliner
$0-26/mo
Audiograms and video clips. Free for educators and nonprofits.

Repurpose.io
$35-179/mo
Cross-platform distribution. Connects RSS to social channels.

Capsho
~$99/mo
Written social copy, newsletters, blog posts. Closest to "agency in a box."

Descript
$0-24/mo
Text-based editing + clip generation + blog/social content from episodes.

Podcasters spend 2-3 hours per episode on social promotion. No single tool handles the full lifecycle. The "agency in a box" for podcasters does not exist yet.

THE OPPORTUNITY

What's Missing From the Market

Structure

No builder provides the right page architecture — sections for long-form show notes, transcripts, FAQs, resources, guest bios. The structure alone is the differentiator.

SEO by Default

JSON-LD, FAQ schema, XML sitemaps, and semantic HTML should be baked into the architecture. Not an upsell. Not a premium feature. Just how it works.

Integration

The content tools exist. The social tools exist. Nobody has connected them to the website. Episode → website → social → traffic back to website.

SOURCES

Market Data & Research

Industry Data

- Independent podcaster survey (558 creators)
- Global podcast market sizing (2025-2026)
- Podcast advertising market reports
- AI in podcasting market analysis
- Apple Podcasts RSS feed specifications

Platform Research

- Podpage, Beamly, OnPodium, ZipiStream pricing
- Transistor, Captivate, Buzzsprout, Podbean, Libsyn, Castos
- CastMagic, Capsho, Deciphr AI, Swell AI, Podium
- Opus Clip, Headliner, Repurpose.io, Descript, Riverside

SEO & Content

- This American Life transcription study
- Schema.org PodcastEpisode/Series specs
- Tim Ferriss, Lex Fridman, Huberman Lab site analysis
- Google AI Overviews citation patterns
- Podcasting 2.0 namespace standards

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Thank You

Questions, thoughts, feedback welcome

Juergen Berkessel · Polymash
juergen@polymash.com